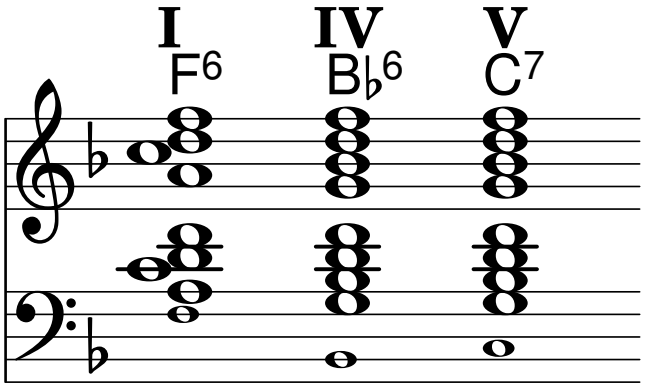
Blues Background Formula

Harmonizing improvised backgrounds over a 12-bar blues in concert F

How it works: one person makes up a background rhythm on the tonic; everyone repeats it.
Next time around each player picks *any* one note out of the formula and moves it with the chords of the blues.
Bottom to top: **I**^{6} = 3 5 6 1 • **IV**^{6} = 6 1 3 5 • **V**^{7} = the same four notes as IV (5 ♭7 9 11 over the V root).
Everyone picks from the four notes of the stack; the small note on the concert bass staff is the root, for the sousaphone.

C (written in F)

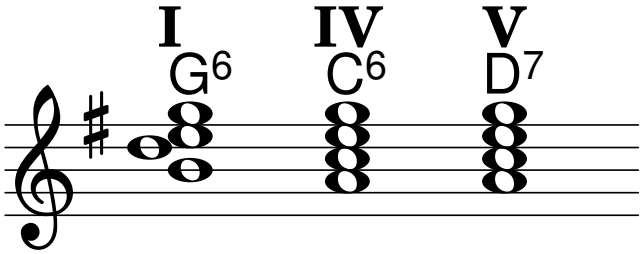
flute · bells · trombone · sousaphone — bass clef reads the lower staff



I F	**I** F	**I** F	**I** F
IV B♭	**IV** B♭	**I** F	**I** F
V C^{7}	**IV** B♭	**I** F	**I** F

B♭ (written in G)

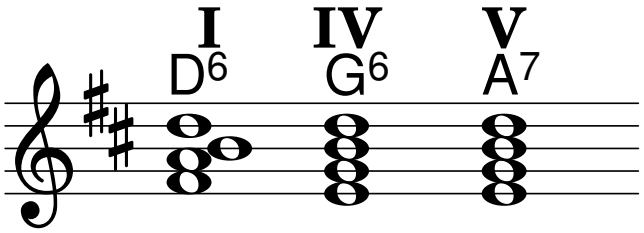
trumpet · clarinet · soprano & tenor sax · baritone · bass sax



I G	**I** G	**I** G	**I** G
IV C	**IV** C	**I** G	**I** G
V D^{7}	**IV** C	**I** G	**I** G

E♭ (written in D)

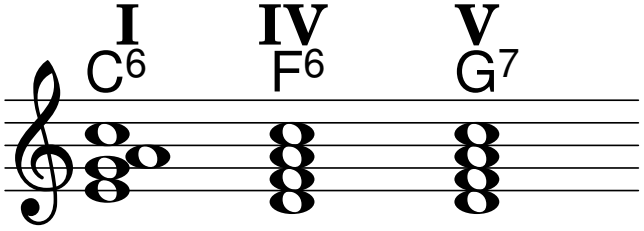
alto sax · bari sax



I D	**I** D	**I** D	**I** D
IV G	**IV** G	**I** D	**I** D
V A^{7}	**IV** G	**I** D	**I** D

F (written in C)

french horn



I C	**I** C	**I** C	**I** C
IV F	**IV** F	**I** C	**I** C
V G^{7}	**IV** F	**I** C	**I** C